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Putter Smith

Putter Smith established himself as a versatile bassist on both coasts. His collaborations on stage and in the studios included work with Thelonious Monk, Art Blakey, The Beach Boys, and Sonny & Cher. He is well known for his brief but memorable acting roles on screen.

Putter was interviewed via Zoom on February 27, 2024 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College and I'd like to welcome Putter Smith today. Thanks for joining me.

PS: Thank you. Thank you very much. Thank you for asking.

MR: I'd like to congratulate you on two things: making a living as a musician, and playing what I consider to be the most important instrument in any band.

PS: Wow. That's a good couple of things. Thank you for both of those. And I always thought it was kind of like — because I'm a bass player when I listen to a band that's what I'm listening to is the the better the bass player, the better the band, and that's how I can tell the difference between Coltrane's I mean Miles's bands, you know I say, "Oh that's Percy Heath," "Oh that's Paul Chambers," "Oh that's Ron Carter."

MR: For you what is the most obvious thing, from that basis, that tells you that, who it is?

PS: Well it's a time feel and there's also a — I read this interview of Pablo Casals and he was talking about how fretless instruments — although he didn't use that term — you can always tell a certain artist by the way they use intonation that makes them sound like they are. So I mean like who's the guy with Jimmy — with Duke Ellington that's credited with starting it all — Jimmy Blanton. He played sharp but it sounded great.

MR: Wow. I've noticed that — I never noticed it with bass players but I noticed it with people like Hugh Masekela, the South African musicians, they seem to be above the pitch. But I'm not sure my ears can hear a bit of sharpness from a bassist. But I guess yours can.

PS: Well it's almost like just a little — it's almost more like a feeling than it really being sharp. And also one of my very favorite bass players and people is Henry Franklin who was Hugh Masekela's bass player. Anyway, yeah Henry!

MR: Yeah. How about that? I love Masekela's music. We almost stumbled upon this question that I have on my list here and that was the concept of time between bassists and drummers. Do you have people you've played with over the years where you really felt like we are locked in and on the other hand people that you never seem to be able to lock in with?

PS: Yes, on every instrument not just drums, but I'm playing with the drummer when I play, I'm playing with the drummer. I mean that's where I'm getting my time is with the drummer. And generally the drummer will say I'm getting it with the bass player. So that's, when you're both doing that that's a great thing. And there are — everybody has something good about them. I mean I love playing with different people and there are some people that are very, very successful that I just do not capture a groove with. And I don't know why but it's just the way it is. Some people call it chemistry but you know it's like a thing where you go um hum this isn't comfortable but you still — on a professional level you're still playing good time, it just doesn't feel comfortable or — I hate to even think about it.

MR: Yeah it doesn't enter into the realm of a train wreck but you're sort of glad when the gig is over perhaps?

PS: Okay again I did not quite hear the last thing you said.

MR: Well I sometimes — sometimes it's like, "Oh yeah the gig was okay but I was glad it was over."

PS: Well that's a good one.

MR: I had an interview recently with a drummer named Ed Soph. And we were talking about this issue. And he said, "I've played with bass players and the first tune I go, "Oh God this guy really plays behind the beat so what I do is I go with that bass player and lock up at the slower tempo. The problem is if when I go down to where he is he continues to slow down. That's a problem."

PS: Well that problem is easily solved by next time he's on the gig turn it down. You know what I mean is you may say oh so-and-so is on the gig. "Oh I just realized I'm busy."

MR: Oh I thought you meant turn the volume down.

PS: No, no, no. No, no. I never fight the drummer, ever. You know it's definitely a losing game.

MR: Yeah that's the old, "Oh I wish I could do it but I'm already booked.

PS: Yeah. "Oh man this thing just came up." Yeah. Yeah.

MR: Do you stall a little bit as if you're pretending to look at your calendar, right?

PS: Oh look here, "Oh God I didn't see this, I'm sorry. Man thanks for calling."

MR: The physicality of playing the bass — did it take you some time as a young man to, I don't know, build up the stamina, the muscles, to play the acoustic bass?

PS: Well yeah. When I started, my first professional gig was 1954. Back then there were no amps and all bass players carried a packet — a little thing of white adhesive tape like present day congolera players have. You know you just tape your fingers And bleeding and blisters were — that was part of it. And you were digging in. You couldn't just turn the volume up you had to dig in you know and generally it was painful for a few minutes

and then you went numb and — but that was the way it was done in those days. The physical part of playing the bass, yes it is a very physical instrument and I was fortunate that I was surrounded by very good bass players and began studying classically when I was about 15. And my first gig was when I was 13 and it was pure guts. I mean just — I don't know do you know that my brother is a famous bass player? Carson Smith?

MR: I do. As a matter of fact —

PS: Oh yeah that looks like him yeah. That's very similar to my brother, yeah. Hey Carson.

MR: That's his gig with Chico Hamilton.

PS: That's right. I know all those guys. I used to see all those guys I was, like I say I was 13 when I started playing. I was about that age when he was working with them. Ten years difference. And let's see where was I going with that?

MR: You were talking about playing without amps and the physicality of it.

PS: Oh yeah well the first gig somebody came up — my brother was famous in jazz at that time. And I was in around ninth grade or tenth grade. And somebody came up to me and said, "Are you Carson's brother?" I said, "Yeah, yeah." He says, "You play the bass?" I go, "Yeah," I lied. And I used to — he had left a half-sized bass there that I used to fool around with and then when his records came out with Chet Baker and Gerry Mulligan I used to play along with those, not knowing anything. All I knew was how it was supposed to sound. And I was playing completely by ear not knowing anything.

MR: Sorry for the interruption — That term, "not knowing anything" I think is an important thing to say. Let me see if I can pin you down. What do you mean by that? "Not knowing anything?"

PS: Names of the notes, keys, chord changes, the proper way to hold the instrument. You know I just — it was pure — what is it, visceral playing. And I knew what it was supposed to sound like and from playing along with the records I — but there was no caution at all, it was just bang — you know, bang bang. And so I took the gig, they picked it up — they didn't call them "gigs" then. That word came in a few years later. And I only had three strings on the bass and I don't really even remember which ones they were, but I knew how to "get down" as they say, you know, and I just got down and within a very short time I was working all the time and consequently missed out on all the social events of my high school because I was always working and all that stuff. And at the time I felt really great about it, but now I kind of wish I had learned to dance with all the lovely young girls in my, you know — we all have regrets, right?

MR: Yes. Was that first gig at the Compton Community Center — was that a dance?

PS: Yeah.

MR: And what kind of tunes would they have been playing?

PS: Well we were playing things like "Moonlight in Vermont," "Blue Moon," and there was a saxophone player out here, Big Jay McNeely.

MR: Sure.

PS: And we were playing all that kind of stuff you know. It was basically blues, which I didn't know was blues, and you just hammer in, you know bang bang bang, just hammer in. And you know the funny thing is if you get two bass players play, and one guy plays perfect notes and doesn't have great time, and the other guy doesn't know a damn thing and has good time, that will make the band feel good. But the guy with bad time will mess everything up. So it's this music. It's music which is kind of evolved from African rhythm. That's what it's totally dependent upon. And that's one of the things I miss about the most modern music, the jazz music where they don't have any time going. It's like, "Come on guys, come on." You know. But then I realize I'm like — when I was in my twenties or something and the older guys, they'd say, "Well what's wrong with the melody?" You know. "What's wrong with playing the melody?" You know. And they were the moldy figs and now I'm a moldy fig you know.

MR: I'm with you.

PS: I want it to swing, man, you know?

MR: I used to belong to, I don't know if it's the musicians' union or people who made mutes or something, they used to send, if you purchased enough material they used to send you a bumper sticker that would say, "Play the Melody."

PS: Oh yeah. Terrific. Yeah.

MR: Did you start to recognize forms like the twelve bar blues or the A-A-B-A thing on your own? Like okay —

PS: I'm sorry go ahead and say it —

MR: Like you're struggling but then you start to realize that the song is starting over and I'm learning it a little bit every time around?

PS: That's right. And the first tune that I realized there were chords in it that I kind of knew what they were was "Perdido" which is one of the things we would play in those days. And I remember talking to the tenor player and telling him, "Look at this" and showing him I could play a C minor and then an F major and then a B flat — and he says, "Oh wow, I didn't know that" you know. Because we were all just ear players, and it's hard to believe, you know, it's hard to believe. But I read a thing about some great players in Chicago, jazz players — a famous guy who I'm sorry I can't name right now but they were famous and became famous and great jazz musicians and they didn't know a damn thing. They got together and they didn't know a damn thing. They just knew what it was supposed to sound like.

MR: I'm just reading a book about Louis Armstrong and he talks about that.

PS: Who?

MR: And King Oliver and some of those early records that, like with the Hot 5, they didn't have any music they just knew the tunes and they knew how to sort of extrapolate on them.

PS: Yeah, yeah. I believe it. I believe.

MR: Well you have a long list of people you've played with of course on gigs but also in the studio, so obviously you had to expand your knowledge to walk into a studio date and fulfill that task?

PS: Well at the age of 16, because I can remember, I can still see it clearly in my mind that I received a message from God and I'm not saying that I was talking to anybody but it was like I had this realization that this is what I'm supposed to do with my life, I'm supposed to be a musician. And I was, you know I read a great deal all my life, much more when I was younger than I do now. And my Mormon heritage, which I was never raised as a Mormon, my father was and he — so we had a list of ancestry, genealogy, they're deep into that. And I've got a couple of American Indian ancestors. And so I've always kind of paid attention to things like receiving your totem and all that kind of stuff, and receiving messages. And just — only twice this has happened, and this all happened when I was 15 or 16. But I kind of went with it and I felt like I had received my message from the one — whoever that is. It's not doing a very good job right now but —

MR: Yeah. That's an interesting story. Do you recall where you were and what you were doing?

PS: Oh yeah. I was in Blue Jay, which is a suburb of Lake Arrowhead, and this is in the mountains above L.A. and there was a group of people that we used to go up there. One of the guy's parents had a large cabin. There was a piano there and there were about eight beds. And we would go up there every five or six weeks, we'd go up there and play all weekend. And that's where I was. And I remember it and I can see it. I can see. I remember where I was standing and, you know —

MR: Wow.

PS: Yeah.

MR: So from that point did you feel it was necessary to start taking lessons? To expand not only your playing of the bass but your understanding of how music works?

PS: Oh yes. Yes. I began studying seriously when I was 16 with the same guy that taught Charlie Mingus and there was a bass player named Jimmy Bond here, and all of the guys studied with this man, whose name is Herman Reinshagen, and the book at that time was the Simandl book, that was the bass study book and that was put together by a guy named Fred Zimmermann. And in the introduction Fred Zimmermann talks about how he was Reinshagen's prize pupil and like that. And so it was really a great privilege to have

studied with Herman. I've studied with, sometimes I say 20 people maybe. Maybe — more than ten people I have studied with. And in school at that time, in high school, junior high and high they had harmony classes, which were the study of, actual study of voice leading. And there were usually about eight people in the class and I had that for about five years and so I was studying and writing stuff and there was one profound book by Paul Hindemith called *Traditional Harmony*. So I attribute my knowledge of the interior of harmony and voice leading and all that stuff from that, and then the other technique, and then I played as much as possible. You know I was obsessive like one needs to be.

MR: What was your record collection like when you were — oh I don't know, 15 or 16?

PS: Bud Powell, Charlie Parker, Bud Powell, Charlie Parker, Art Blakey, Gerry Mulligan, Chet Baker, Art Tatum was a huge — I just listened to Art Tatum all the time. And all those guys. And then a few years later Billie Holiday came in the thing and I still listen to music — when I find something I need I listen to it obsessively. Mostly I don't listen to music at all anymore but that's — the record with Bud Powell and Bird and Jazz at Massey Hall — even though it's a big mess, Charlie Parker's — Jesus — Charlie Parker, the greatest, the greatest, the greatest. Genius like, and almost everybody else is building on somebody else but Charlie Parker was, Holy my God, sprung forth from what is it, sprung forth from Jupiter's brow.

MR: Yes I know there was some kind of historical reference there. Would there be any pop music of the day in your record collection? Let's say early rock & roll or, you know, later on Motown etcetera?

PS: No. I just had a period where I was in the studios playing that kind of music but the jazz musicians always — and it was reciprocated, that is jazz musicians always knew that we were far above the rock & roll players. And rock & roll players always admired us as real musicians. But that's no longer the case. And I saw a show the other day and I think it was Quincy Jones said — and he was talking about Miles Davis. He said, "When money comes in the room God leaves." I wouldn't go that far but it's certainly apparent that money is a corrupting influence. And fortunately we're still an art. We're still really an art and still sharing.

MR: Yes. I remember reading a quote from you that — I believe you stated jazz is still an art form because money can't really be a part of it — or something like that.

PS: From me?

MR: Yes.

PS: Well okay I'll try to keep this not so lengthy but I saw a show a few years ago about modern art, about the art world, which I'm — my first girlfriend's father was a modern painter, and so I got real interested you know. I was 15 or 16 and I got real interested and

started reading all — looking at these pictures. I wasn't reading so much. And have a taste, and then when I was on the road and everything I would — we'd be in a town and I'd hit all the museums they got in there and I had favorite artists. And I feel like I'm an aficionado (even though I can't pronounce it) I love art. I love art. And, but this show was talking about in the '50s that the artists in New York that they would kind of congregate in this one bar, it was their bar you know like, what was the name of the one the jazz guys hung out in New York? Famous?

MR: Oh yes. Andy's? Jim & Andy's?

PS: No, somewhere else. Something else. I can't remember but anyway it was one where guys like Zoot Sims and everybody there, everybody would be there, Bill Crow mentions it every once in a while. And by the way I find Bill Crow's writings so interesting.

MR: As do I.

PS: Yeah. But they would get together, all these artists and they would share ideas and they'd have little exhibitions of their own work to each other and talk about they're working on this and then they'd all say yeah, oh yeah, okay good, let's try — you know, and they're selling their paintings like $500 was a huge amount to get for a painting for one of these people, you know guys. And then this guy come along who said, "I can turn this into a big business." And he did. And I don't know his name but he was like an art promoter and next thing you know these guys are selling paintings at auction for like $100,000, I mean that are now selling for 1.9 million. You know. But everything changed. Everything changed. They no longer — they don't want to show each other what they're doing. They don't take it to there and hang out. You know their exhibitions are — you know they become very isolated and rich. And one of the upshots of the show is that people with — one of their main problems in the world is paying taxes — they'll buy a piece by a very mediocre prominent artist, and I'm speaking of a guy named Jeffrey Koons — K-O-O-N-S. And I mean you go like my God, this is the kind of stuff you'd see at Toys R Us. And I mean you know, and I mean I really love art. I mean I love DeChirico and all sorts of people. And they'll pay him $80,000 for this erector set thing, and then three years later it'll be worth $2.9 million. They'll contribute it to a museum and get a tax write-off of $2.9 million dollars and it only cost them $80,000. You see? And that's the business that's going on in art. And there was one art critic that explained it very carefully and I went that's exactly what's happening you know. Well you can't sell a bass solo.

MR: There's no physical product — like I see what you're saying. Of course you can record it but it doesn't have the same — it's not tangible.

PS: You can't own it.

MR: You can't own it.

PS: Yeah.

MR: That's very profound.

PS: Okay. I've got a million of 'em.

MR: Well we'll just keep track of how many.

PS: That's one.

MR: Well I'll mark it over here. Your list of studio work includes everyone from Sonny & Cher to Beck if this list is correct. When was the last — do you remember first of all the last studio date, like showing up to play a part? When was the most recent one for you?

PS: Well the thing with Beck was last year but that was a total fluke. I'm not in that business anymore at all, it was a total fluke. There was a country western swing player, guitar player, named Smokey Hormel and we met in New York, actually New Jersey, and I began going to see his gig in Red Hook. And I enjoyed it very much. And these guys were really good country & western players, and I mean really good you know, really good. And there's a swinging bunch of guys you know. And I mean I'm not that kind of a player or anything like that. And so anyway Smokey called me up and he says, "I'm coming to L.A. and I've got this gig and I want you to play on it." I said, "Man I don't know any of that music." He says, "I'll send you a list, it's all on YouTube." "Okay, okay." Because I like him so much, he was such a great guy. So I spent, you know some hours getting it together and went and did the gig and it was a lot of fun, a lot of fun. It was silly you know. I don't mean it was silly, it wasn't silly, it was real. It was real. But I mean I'm playing bluegrass kind of bass you know. Bluegrass kind of, you know like [scats] you know that, and I'm being real. I'm not being silly about it, you know I'm seriously playing it, you know, giving it my heart. And so anyway Smokey is a friend of Beck. And Beck came into the gig and he says, "I want you guys to record." You know. So great, okay. So we went over to Beck and I made a fortune in one day. But before that my studio work, Sonny & Cher circa, that was in the middle-'60s. And my dear old friend Don Randi, I was working with Don at this club six nights a week making $86 a week, had gotten married recently and had a second child. And six nights a week and we were very happy and everything. And then he said, "If you get an electric bass," he says, "I can get you some recording work." And I said, "Okay, fine" you know. "Cause you're supporting a family" you know. But we were renting a three bedroom house for $75 a month. This was just a different world. And so I began doing all these dates and I was doing like five, sometimes five a week with all sorts of people. And you know all that kind of stuff. And I went into — one day after about three or four years of doing this I went into one date and it was for Cher, not Sonny and Cher, just Cher and it was — I can't think of the guy's name. One of his names was Gene, a writer. And he had "Up a Lazy River" written in real nice, James Jamerson kind of bass line you know like [scats]

You know nice, fun. And the producer goes, "Can you play it — make it a little simpler?" I said, "Oh okay." So [scats]. He says, "Can you make it a little simpler?" [scats] He said, "Well can you make it a little simpler?" So I go to like the nastiest, dirtiest commercial and I go [scats]. He goes, "Yeah, that's it." And at that moment I decided this is not why I became a musician. This is not why I became a musician. And I just simply stopped hustling those kind of gigs and within three months I was totally out. You know. I was totally out. And that was fine, and then I began doing some really good big time work, and I mean more on my career. So I was doing really good, good work that I loved and everything, and then I got called to do that film. I guess you know about that right?

MR: I do. And I was going to get to that. Before we go there I've spoken to L.A. studio guys who did that, three dates a day for years and years.

PS: Say that?

MR: They do these studio dates three times a day for years.

PS: Yes.

MR: And I guess I'm wondering how they continued to do it, contrasting with the fact that you said this is not for me anymore? I guess I don't expect you to speak for them but perhaps it's a financial consideration or that they had enough other things on the side that kept them creatively happy.

PS: There were several of us that did the same thing at different times I've read about later. I mean I used to be on dates with Barney Kessel and I heard that he said, "Oh F this" and stopped. And Carol Kaye — I used to be on dates with her. And I did a lot of those Phil Spector dates where he had five bass players. You know. Absurd.

MR: I've never understood how could that possibly work? Did he have someone write out the bass lines so that everybody was playing the same thing?

PS: We're all playing [scats]. Yeah I'm telling you, that's the truth. Yeah. It's all written out you know and that's where the kind of lines, they were stupid. And we were all like this is ridiculous you know. And he had an upright bass which was Lyle Ritz, and Carole, a single Danelectro bass, a kind of weird bass, and Larry Knechtel would be playing Fender bass, and somebody else was playing guitarron and somebody else was playing another bass. They were all playing the same thing. And well whenever any one of them would take off to do something else, Lyle would take their instrument and call me to play the upright bass so —

MR: When you listen to those records now if you happen to be in your car and you've got the oldies station on, first of all do you recognize things that you played on?

PS: No.

MR: You do not?

PS: Nope. No it was commercial, mediocre, and people tell me, they say, "Oh you're on that, that's a classic, that's a classic." Well no, no, Charlie Parker on "Jazz at Massey Hall" that's a classic. Art Tatum playing "Tenderly," that's a classic. You know? Billie Holiday singing anything you know, those are classics.

MR: Okay. Before we leave that I just looked to my left here and amongst the people I see you've played with if this is correct is a drummer named Jimmy Wormworth.

PS: Well yeah, I met Jimmy in New York through Mike Kanan which actually came through Jorge Rossi. I had a short period, five or six years, where I was going back to New York about every six weeks I would go for ten days. I had a room I rented from Mike Kanan and his wife Stephanie. And I was doing a lot of work and I began to turn down some work because all I wanted to do was play with those guys, you know, and Mike had a studio and so I was playing — I would get to New York about 6 or 7 the plane would come in at night and I'd be at the apartment about 7:30 you know and he'd say, "Do you want to play?" And I'd, "Yeah." And he'd get on the phone and an hour later we're in the studio playing see that's the wonderful thing about New York City. It's packed with people that want to play all the time, want to play all the time. And that's why they're there. I regret not having gone to — I don't regret the life I've had, but I regret not having gone to New York when I was twenty and come up there. Because it's really the jazz center of the world. I don't know how the people can make it there now. Rents are so high and gigs are paying $50 and a plate of spaghetti you know, and the spaghetti is a very important part of it you know.

MR: Play for your supper. I mentioned Jimmy Wormworth because he's from Utica where I am, and he is a well known local figure. I found on the internet the video, and I wonder if you remember this, it came from 1987 from the Guitar Institute and you're playing with Ed Thigpen and Ron — a guitar player Ron?

PS: Ron Eschete.

MR: Eschete. And you're playing "Oleo." And this thing was so fast that I got out an on-line metronome and I tried to figure out the tempo. And it's so fast that it was off the chart. And I had to figure out okay what are the beats per minute of the half note. And this thing was like 320 beats per minute. Do you remember this?

PS: Oh yeah. Oh yeah. No I saw that, someone sent that to me in the last couple of years. And I said my God how did I do it? How could I do it?

MR: And you played the melody.

PS: Well that's the easy part. It's going bing-bing-bing-bing-bing-bing that's the hard part. You know. Ed Thigpen, a great drummer.

MR: Yeah. I was stunned by that. I had a quote here from Chubby Jackson. And we were talking about, you know as a bass player we were talking about that. And he said — I

thought of him back then watching Woody Herman's band with the lack of amplification and he said, "A lot of times your arms and fingers get numb. You're playing — you start to shake physically at the moment, and then someone looks at you and says 'take one' the laugh of the century, somebody points to the bass player after 28 choruses, your hands are like this. My hands were so ugly I used to keep them in my pocket all the time."

PS: Yeah. Absolutely. And he was playing without an amp. And he was a very good bass player. His son was out here for a while, Duffy. Very good drummer. Very good drummer. I think he ended up in Miami. But Chubby was a very good bass player.

MR: Well with a song like that, at that tempo, I'm trying to form a question here — how many of your notes would you not play if you were playing at a civilized tempo?

PS: Can you rephrase that? How many notes would I NOT play?

MR: I guess what I'm trying to say is, is there just like I'm going to survive this and I'm going to keep playing, but some of these notes that I'm playing are not really by choice, it's just to keep the time?

PS: Well it's kind of all a choice. I mean you just play the line, you just follow the line. I mean the way I play I'm just following the line and, but I'm at the age now where I can go, "Hey!" And also they don't play at that tempo anymore. Nobody does.

MR: Yeah I think they outlawed that.

PS: No. You just play. You're playing the same thing, you're just — bass lines are, there's a certain kind of — in the music of the '50s, '60s is, there are a lot of boundaries in bass lines and things that make it sound like a bass and make the horn player comfortable. That's one of the roles of the rhythm section is to be comfortable for the horn player so generally, just roughly you'd say you know, you want to — whenever the chord changes you want to play the root or the third of that note. And so it sounds like you've changed chords. And then the next notes are lead-ins to the next one. So you really have a fairly narrow field of — it's not like Art Tatum playing long lines and stuff and the ability to do that. Because the horn players, they need to feel comfortable. Just like the bass players need to feel comfortable when they're soloing, and there are very few pianists that have any idea how to play — how to comp — when there's no bass playing or bass line. Okay? And I'll explain that a little bit. It's like what the bass provides, a very strong definition of where the chord change — as I said by playing either the root or the third on one, and when they're not doing that, while they're doing that then other people could do like, you know like tempo says one, two, three, four [scats] You know those are kind of comping things that a piano player or a guitar player would play. You know it's almost like what a snare drum on an older drummers would play like hits, like little accents and everything. But they are just, they're nice as long as you've got the bass player. But when the bass player stops playing they don't help at all. They don't tell you where one is

or where is it, you know because it's an affirmation thing, you know, group improvisation. Okay I'm sorry, I'm going on too long.

MR: No, I know what you're saying. It's like piano players like Ralph Sutton and Dave McKenna, they had that thing that you're describing. They had that left hand sense of —

PS: Yeah, right

MR: I can keep this going. But going way back to when we started talking today you've just defined really why I wasn't kidding when I said that the most important instrument in the band, I've always felt that the bass player is it. And you know the drummer can kind of indicate a different feel — okay we're going from two beat to four beat — but if the bass player doesn't go there it's not going there at all.

PS: Yeah. Hey I bow to your comprehension. That's true. That's true. If the bass player is good everything's good. If the bass player is bad, everything's bad.

MR: Well said.

PS: Yeah.

MR: You probably have run into people who think that you — when they find out that you play the bass they probably say, "Wow, you're an actor and you also play the bass."

PS: Yeah, right.

MR: Instead of the other way around.

PS: Well I don't run into that too much because where I play there are usually audiences, jazz audiences. And I have to say, because they say, "He's also an actor." "No, no, I'm not an actor. Alec Guinness is an actor. Meryl Streep is an actor, you know George Clooney is an actor. I'm a guy that was in a movie, but I never did anything special or anything, it was just a freak occurrence that put me in the movie and my wife says, "You've got to do it, you've got to do it."

MR: When you got on the set and got into that whole process, coming from a world —

PS: You're talking about the movie set?

MR: Yes. The movie set.

PS: Okay.

MR: Coming from a world in music where much of what you did was based and required improvisation, something different, was it a shock to you to do the takes over and over and it had to be the same way every time? Was it hard to adjust to that?

PS: Well my wife was an actress and she was very, very good. And she was into, she never made any real money, she was in a couple of TV shows, but she — I used to help her with, she was improvising, and really very very good, when they had improvising theater. And so I used to, whenever she would have a part that she needed to study I would read, so I knew how to read a script. But now I'm starting — I went into a rearranged rap and I can't remember what your question was.

MR: Well I just contrasted —

PS: Oh yeah, improvising. No I never thought of anything like that. It was just like I called around to different people and I said, "Gee I'm in this movie, what should I do?" And I called Med Flory and he was very, he was the only one that gave me good advice. He said, "Just remember they're going to shoot the scene from different angles, just try to remember what your hands are doing when you're saying certain things, and try to do it the same way. And that was the best advice I got. You know like, so after that I became aware of watching things and you see Burt Lancaster in an early movie where he's eating with his fork and they cut away and they come back and instead of his fork in his right hand he's got his spoon in his left hand. And you go oh, yeah, but that was a very good piece of advice from Med you know. And one of the actors I worked with I went the first day and I said, "Well you know I've never done this before, you know if you can give me any tips I'd appreciate it." And he says, "Just shut up and stay in the background." And I thought, "Well thank you very, very much, now I know exactly who you are." You know and I've worked with plenty of people like you before and I know exactly, if I just stay completely — it actually gave me strength you know, knowing I was dealing with a jerk. But speaking of not-jerks, Sean Connery, wonderful guy, wonderful guy. And Jill St. John, wonderful chick. She was like a real musician's kind of chick. And she had been married to Tom, what's his name, I can't remember his name, a singer that sings kind of like Frank Sinatra, a very good singer.

MR: Tom Jones?

PS: Jack Jones.

MR: Jack Jones.

PS: That's right. Jack Jones, yeah Jack Jones. And she was lovely. She was lovely. But anyway, so it was, you know an experience not to be I don't know if I did the right thing to do it but I did it. My wife said, "You've got to do it, you've got to do it. You're not going to get another call like that."

MR: Yeah I was just imagining, you know my wife and I we have a little routine sort of when I get home from a gig she might say, "How'd it go?" Or the next morning if there was something of significance I might say, "Guess what happened last night." So I'm envisioning the morning after that gig with Thelonious Monk where this guy comes up to you and makes this request.

PS: Oh well that, it was months after the gig with Thelonious. It was months later. And I was coming home from a pretty stupid gig, which you know you work a number of them in the tuxedo at a country club with an accordion player, you know, like you're feeding your family. And so I come home, it's about 8:00 and my wife is standing at the door and she's — my wife's father and my wife passed away three years ago. My wife's father

was a pugilist. He was a prizefighter and he was in the same stables as Jack Dempsey so he was really good. And his wife said, he says, "It's either me or boxing. You have to give up boxing if you want me." His wife. And so he gave up boxing. But he taught his daughter how to box. My wife. And she would, when she would get angry she would assume a pugilistic stance. You know? She just would get into that stance as if she was going to hit me. And she was standing at the door and she says, "You just got the call to go with Thelonious and you better say yes."

MR: That's terrific.

PS: I mean everything that I ever did is because of her. I mean she was the most wonderful partner for me, for a jazz musician. And she loved the music.

MR: You were speaking about comping and piano players. I wonder if working with Thelonious and his distinctive style of playing affected the way you played? Did you feel you needed to play slightly different with him?

PS: No. No I was playing for Thelonious and I had been listening to Thelonious since I was 16 and avidly, and very familiar with his music. And I had transcribed some of his more difficult tunes and on the west coast there weren't that many people that were into Thelonious at all. But I just really loved his compositions and he had a peculiar way, and I was, as years have gone on and I've broadened my scope of understanding of time — what they used to say well you know he plays these, he kind of plays these — he's dragging these triplets you know in a certain way. And they go that's Thelonious, you know, he kind of drags the triplets and this thing. But you know when I studied, oh I guess it was 25 years ago I began studying five-tuplets, you know, and so I spent six months studying that and everything and becoming like an eighth note five-tuplet is a quarter note five-tuplets, half note five-tuplets, and to where it becomes — and the process for me has always been I'll get a night, and for some reason I want to do this. So I spent this time trying to assimilate five-tuplets and trying to put it my playing and it wouldn't go. You know. And so finally after six months I said okay that's — and then two years later I'm listening to a playback of something I'm on, a recording, and I listened back and I'm playing perfect five-tuplets. And they don't sound weird at all. And the music is full of them. You know like a lot of tunes are full of five-tuplets. And then when I heard, you know I don't listen to Thelonious like sometimes maybe for five years you know I don't listen to him. And then I heard a Thelonious thing and I realized, my God he's playing perfect five-tuplets. Perfect five-tuplets. Only he's able to mix in triplets and sixteens and five-tuplets. You know? And threw it all in, but it's all in time. He's never dragging. And he was so — anyway —

MR: Was it apparent on the gig — did he show pleasure or otherwise with the way the band was sounding? Could you tell if he was pleased or not?

PS: Oh yeah. No I was called to work a week — two weeks in San Francisco. And in the middle of the second week he had — and I hung out with him every minute, I mean, and he wasn't strange, you know like they always picture him as a weirdo, he's not weird. Not at all. You know and he's not effusive. He'd go sometimes a couple of days and not say anything at all, but if you're not afraid of large black men, you know, all you have to do is be around a few and you realize hey man, like I think that, you know this is my own opinion I think writers, first they form an opinion like oh my God, you know, oh my God, this guy is scary, he's scary and he's going to steal my car you know. And then when a writer is, they're going to pay you $40 to write a review of a performance and you have to go to the gig and buy a drink and, you know you end up like, that a large amount of the writing comes from reading previous reviews. Because it becomes like written in stone that Thelonious is strange. He's not strange. He's a little bit shy and also he's funny as hell. But anyway so I don't know if it was in the ending of the first week or the middle of the second he said to me, he says, "You want to go to Shelly's with me?" You know he had gotten a call. The reason I got the gig was because he had done a tour of Asia and Bill Cosby at that time was paying jazz musicians who wanted to become actors, paying their admission, their tuition to Manhattan School of Acting. And so the bass player and the tenor player, I think it was Charlie Rouse and I'm not sure if it was Bob Cranshaw, but it was somebody like that, they had to be back to New York. So Thelonious got this last minute booking in San Francisco and so they were looking for a bass player and I got recommended by several people who knew I knew his stuff. Anyway he said, "Do you want to go to Shelly's with me?" And my tail is still wagging.

MR: That's a great way to put it.

PS: Yeah. What a wonderful guy.

MR: You passed the audition. Did he speak to the audience on gigs?

PS: No he didn't do announcing or anything like that. He — one time he said something and it illustrates his humor. His theme song was "Epistrophy" do you know that song? [scats] And so this one set, this was in San Francisco. Now what I'm going to do is the lady says something and then Monk says it back and to get the thing I'm going to just do it without saying he said/she said. And so you can tell I've told this story a number of times. So this set, he would play the head and then he would get up and dance through the whole thing and then sit down and play the thing out. Did that with every tune in the set. And then played the [scats] the theme to go out. And then he stood up to dance again, and the lady says, "Monk, I paid good money to see you." "Are you blind?" That was the thing. And the entire — the band and the entire audience just went, you know laughed like crazy. It was definitely worth the price of admission you know. And people would say things to him, was he across, you know, going into the gig and such, and people would say

something and he'd answer them. And the things that I thought were amazing other people were offended you know. And one of the things somebody said, "What about God, Thelonious?" "God is my slave!" I thought that was wonderful. "God is my slave." "Yeah baby."

MR: That is unique.

PS: It is unique. Yeah. Okay so anyway, sorry.

MR: That's fine. Just to wrap up, are you a person who thinks about the good old days, that reminisces and thinks that things now are not nearly as positive as they used to be?

PS: Oh of course. Of course. I'm an old man. I mean that's the birthright of old men you know. I read this thing that said that young people today have no respect for their elders, they have no respect for like traditional ways and politeness and, I'm paraphrasing, and on and on, and it was a speech made by Cicero 2500 years ago. So there you go.

MR: Well musically when, I don't know if this is answerable, but musically when did the good old days start to pass?

PS: The good old days?

MR: I guess I'm thinking some of the musicians I've talked to, studio guys, they talk about this bit, some of them will be dramatic about it. "I can remember when we went to A&M Studios and we saw the first synthesizer." As if that was like an alarm bell going off.

PS: That was a what going on?

MR: Like an alarm bell, like we've seen the future and we don't like it.

PS: No I was in Japan and saw it there before it was here and I bought one. It was $1,100. And it was like oh my God this is great, there was no kind of an alarm bell. I brought it home and I was programming Bach fugues on it and stuff like that you know. Because you could do it one note at a time. Because I'm not a piano player you know. And somebody came over and I said, "Listen to this." And I turned it on and said, "I did this." You know? "My God, I didn't know you played piano." So it was like a great tool but the recording industry is a whole different line of work. It's like rock & roll and then there's pop stuff and I mean stuff like Johnny Mathis and Tony Bennett quality, Frank Sinatra. And I guess I listened — just the other day I listened, just because — Taylor Swift, you know I listened to her thing and it was like well that didn't bother me you know. I mean it didn't bother me. And it wasn't like Mick Jagger. That bothers me. But I mean I feel like we're people that — I hate to use the word "real jazz" but people that are devoted to improvising and that's evolving and it's been evolving. It's just going on and it's a great art form and there are thousands of young people involved in this art form. And as to how many of them will last, but the good old days, I don't know it's always like when you're 20 you go, "Oh yeah man, I missed out on the good old days," you know. The good old

days were the last ten years you know. So maybe the good old days is always the old days you know. Geez remember back in 2009, remember back then? Gee I don't know.

MR: I can't remember that, 2009.

PS: I can't remember what I had for dinner last night. I mean I'm getting to the age where certain old things that were funny are now crude like. I've forgotten more than you'll ever know.

MR: Okay. Well can you remember what's the next gig that's coming up for you?

PS: I'm doing a little concert at the church, Pasadena Presbyterian and that thing with a guy that I'm rehearsing with today, we're in the middle of making an album, Jeff Colella, a lovely piano player. We're doing that now. We're recording in a month. And work is very scarce, very scarce. And I'm at the point now where I turn down far more than I do because first of all I can't play a four hour gig, it's too long. I'm going to bed now by 10:00 at night. So a gig that ends at 9:00 is like oh man, there's got to be something really good about it. I mean that's the way it is you know. There's a magazine called The Sun — S-U-N and on the back page they have little blurbs and the theme this one week was "the last years of your life" and one lady said, "I'm just trying to fall apart gracefully." That's beautiful. That's beautiful.

MR: I'm going to keep that in mind in the next few years.

PS: Yeah, it's a good one.

MR: It's been a real pleasure speaking with you and again, congratulations on your career, and thanks for sharing today.

PS: Well thank you. I really enjoyed it very, very much.

MR: Excellent.

PS: Okay. And do you have — my daughter wants to know if she can watch this.

MR: Yes. It will be within a couple of weeks it will be up on our Fillius Jazz YouTube channel and I will send you a link when we put it up.

PS: Real good.

MR: Excellent.

PS: Thank you. Thank you very, very much, Monk.

MR: You're welcome. I'm going to sign off and then we'll say our official good-byes.

PS: Okay so do we do that now or?

MR: Yeah I'm just going to pause this. Excellent.